

Later, Leonardo told stories that may well have been inspired by the everyday things around him. He once wrote a fable, for example, that told of a majestic cedar tree. This tree was so proud of its own beauty that it would not allow any lowly plants to grow near its trunk. That was all very well, until a strong wind came along. With no other plants to protect it, the tree was torn out of the ground and toppled over.

Even as a little boy, Leonardo may have understood that pride and arrogance were not qualities he wanted to adopt. Going forward, he would try to keep that in mind. But right now, his life was like a blank canvas, just waiting to be painted.

